

Getting Started with headless-pm

From zero to your first AI-powered PM workflow — no coding required.

Choose your OS

→ [macOS](#) · [Linux](#) · [Windows WSL2](#)

macOS

1. Prerequisites

Before you start, make sure you have accounts on these three platforms. All of them offer free tiers that work with headless-pm.

Account	What it's for	Sign up
Anthropic	Claude CLI — your main AI assistant	claude.ai
Google	Gemini CLI — free unlimited tier, great for long documents	gemini.google.com
OpenAI	Codex CLI — code generation and scripting	platform.openai.com

You don't need to add a credit card or create API keys. headless-pm connects via browser login.

2. Open Terminal

Press **Cmd + Space**, type **Terminal**, press **Enter**.

You'll see a window with a prompt that looks like this:

```
username@MacBook ~ %
```

That `%` (or `$`) means Terminal is ready for your commands. Everything in this guide gets typed here.

Tip: Want a nicer terminal experience? Install [Warp](#) — it has autocomplete and is easier to use than the default Terminal.

```
# Optional: paste this to install Warp
brew install --cask warp
```

Verify: You see a prompt with `%` or `$`.

3. Install Node.js

headless-pm runs on Node.js. First, install Homebrew (macOS package manager), then Node.js.

Step 1 — Install Homebrew (if you don't have it):

```
/bin/bash -c "$(curl -fsSL
```

```
https://raw.githubusercontent.com/Homebrew/install/HEAD/install.sh)"
```

This will ask for your Mac password. Type it (nothing appears on screen — that's normal) and press Enter.

Step 2 — Install Node.js:

```
brew install node
```

Verify:

```
node --version
```

Expected output: `v20.x.x` or higher (any v18+ is fine).

4. Install AI CLIs

Install all three CLIs with one command each. Each one opens your browser for login — no API keys needed.

Claude CLI:

```
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code  
claude
```

Your browser opens → log in with your Anthropic account → close the browser tab → return to Terminal.

Verify:

```
claude --version
```

Gemini CLI:

```
npm install -g @google/gemini-cli  
gemini
```

Your browser opens → log in with your Google account → close the browser tab → return to Terminal.

Verify:

```
gemini --version
```

Codex CLI:

```
npm install -g @openai/codex  
codex
```

Your browser opens → log in with your OpenAI account → close the browser tab → return to Terminal.

Verify:

```
codex --version
```

All three commands should print a version number. If one fails, that's fine — headless-pm works with whichever CLIs you have installed.

5. Set Up Your Workspace

headless-pm reads a `.pm/` folder in your project directory. This folder holds your product context — sprint state, focus, blockers — so the AI always knows what you're working on.

Create the workspace for your product:

```
mkdir -p ~/projects/my-product/.pm/artifacts
cd ~/projects/my-product
```

Replace `my-product` with the name of your actual product (e.g., `my-saas-app`, `analytics-platform`).

Your workspace structure:

```
my-product/
├── .pm/
│   ├── STATE.md      ← sprint state, focus, blockers
│   └── artifacts/    ← PRD, backlog, sprint plans, etc.
```

Verify:

```
ls .pm/
```

Expected output: `artifacts/`

6. Load Your Product Context

Open a text editor and create `.pm/STATE.md` with this content. Fill in your own product details.

```
# Open the file in nano (simple editor):
nano .pm/STATE.md
```

Paste this template and fill it in:

```
- Product: [your product name]
- Phase: Discover
- Sprint: 1 (ends 2026-06-01)
- Focus: [what you're working on this sprint]
- Blockers: none

## Context
[Write 2-3 sentences about your product: what it does, who uses it, and what stage
```

```
you're at. Example: "B2B analytics dashboard for e-commerce teams. We're pre-launch, currently in closed beta with 5 teams. Focus is on reducing time-to-first-insight."]
```

Save: press **Ctrl+O**, then **Enter**, then **Ctrl+X** to exit.

Example of a filled STATE.md:

```
- Product: DataPulse
- Phase: Build
- Sprint: 3 (ends 2026-06-15)
- Focus: Onboarding flow redesign – reduce drop-off at step 2
- Blockers: waiting on design review from Sara
```

Context

```
B2B analytics dashboard for e-commerce teams tracking conversion funnels. We're in closed beta with 12 paying customers. The main problem we're solving is that existing tools require SQL – our customers are non-technical ops managers.
```

Verify: Run `cat .pm/STATE.md` — you should see your content.

7. Install headless-pm

```
npx headless-pm install
```

What happens:

- Detects which CLIs you have installed (Claude, Gemini, Codex)
- Installs PM skills into each one
- Installs the knowledge base to `~/.headless/pm/`
- Asks if you want to connect Notion, Linear, or other tools (press Enter to skip for now)

If you have a license key (from your purchase email): enter it when prompted. All 56 skills install.

If you don't have a key yet: press Enter to skip. Stage 1 (Discovery) and Stage 2 (Definition) skills install for free — 13 skills total.

Verify:

```
claude --version
```

If Claude installed successfully: `npx headless-pm install` has finished.

8. First Run

Open Claude Code in your product folder:

```
cd ~/projects/my-product
claude
```

Type this inside Claude Code:

/pm

You'll see a dashboard like this:

DataPulse · Sprint 3 · 2026-06-01 → 2026-06-15 · 14d

DISCOVERY

✓ insights
○ interviews
○ clusters

DEFINE

○ prd
○ backlog
○ acceptance

BUILD

○ sprint
○ stories

SHIP

○ release
○ retro

Blockers: waiting on design review from Sara
Focus: Onboarding flow redesign – reduce drop-off at step 2

Next step: /pm-prd – no PRD found, recommend starting here

What each part means:

- **DISCOVERY / DEFINE / BUILD / SHIP** — the four PM phases. ✓ = artifact exists, ○ = not yet created.
- **Blockers / Focus** — pulled directly from your STATE.md
- **Next step** — the skill the AI recommends based on your current state

Try these first:

/pm-prd

write a PRD for your current focus

/cusdev

prepare a customer interview (Mom Test)

/pm-sprint-plan

plan your sprint

Troubleshooting (macOS)

Problem	Fix
brew: command not found	Homebrew isn't installed. Run the install script from Step 3.
npm: command not found	Run brew install node first.
claude: command not found	Run npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code again. Then run claude to log in.
npx: command not found	Run brew install node. npx comes with Node.js.
node --version shows v16 or lower	Run brew upgrade node.
Browser doesn't open during claude login	Try claude --no-browser and follow the manual login instructions.
/pm shows "No skills found"	Run npx headless-pm install again from your product folder.

Permission error on `npm install -g`

Run `sudo npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code` (adds sudo).

Linux

These instructions are tested on Ubuntu 22.04 / Debian 12. For Fedora/RHEL, swap `apt` commands for `dnf`.

1. Prerequisites

Account	What it's for	Sign up
Anthropic	Claude CLI	claude.ai
Google	Gemini CLI	gemini.google.com
OpenAI	Codex CLI	platform.openai.com

2. Open Terminal

Press **Ctrl + Alt + T**. On most Linux distros this opens the default terminal.

If that doesn't work: open your Applications menu and search for "Terminal".

Verify: You see a prompt with `$`.

3. Install Node.js

Ubuntu / Debian:

```
sudo apt update
sudo apt install -y nodejs npm
```

Fedora / RHEL:

```
sudo dnf install -y nodejs npm
```

Verify:

```
node --version
```

Expected: `v18.x.x` or higher. If you get v16 or lower, install a newer version:

```
# Ubuntu/Debian - install Node.js 20 via NodeSource:
curl -fsSL https://deb.nodesource.com/setup_20.x | sudo -E bash -
sudo apt install -y nodejs
```

4. Install AI CLIs

Claude CLI:

```
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
claude
```

Your browser opens → log in with Anthropic account → return to Terminal.

Verify: `claude --version`

Gemini CLI:

```
npm install -g @google/gemini-cli
gemini
```

Your browser opens → log in with Google account → return to Terminal.

Verify: `gemini --version`

Codex CLI:

```
npm install -g @openai/codex
codex
```

Your browser opens → log in with OpenAI account → return to Terminal.

Verify: `codex --version`

Note: On some Linux systems, `npm install -g` requires `sudo`: `sudo npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code`

5. Set Up Your Workspace

```
mkdir -p ~/projects/my-product/.pm/artifacts
cd ~/projects/my-product
```

Verify: `ls .pm/` → shows `artifacts/`

6. Load Your Product Context

```
nano .pm/STATE.md
```

Paste and fill in:

```
- Product: [your product name]
- Phase: Discover
- Sprint: 1 (ends 2026-06-01)
- Focus: [what you're working on this sprint]
- Blockers: none
```

Context

[2–3 sentences about your product: what it does, who uses it, current stage.]

Save: **Ctrl+O** → **Enter** → **Ctrl+X**

Verify: `cat .pm/STATE.md`

7. Install headless-pm

```
npx headless-pm install
```

Enter your license key when prompted (or press Enter to install free skills).

8. First Run

```
cd ~/projects/my-product
claude
```

Inside Claude Code, type:

```
/pm
```

You'll see the PM dashboard. Try:

```
/pm-prd      # write a PRD
/cusdev      # customer interview prep
/pm-sprint-plan # plan your sprint
```

Troubleshooting (Linux)

Problem	Fix
node --version shows v16 or lower	Install Node.js 20 via NodeSource (see Step 3).
npm: command not found	Run <code>sudo apt install npm</code> (Ubuntu) or <code>sudo dnf install npm</code> (Fedora).
Permission error on <code>npm install -g</code>	Add sudo prefix, or configure npm prefix: <code>mkdir ~/.npm-global && npm config set prefix ~/.npm-global && echo 'export PATH=~/.npm-global/bin:\$PATH' >> ~/.bashrc && source ~/.bashrc</code>
Browser doesn't open during CLI login	Run the CLI command, then manually open the URL it prints in your browser.
<code>/pm</code> shows "No skills found"	Run <code>npx headless-pm install</code> again.

Windows (WSL2)

headless-pm runs inside WSL2 (Windows Subsystem for Linux). This gives you a full Linux environment on Windows. Setup takes about 10 minutes.

1. Prerequisites

Account	What it's for	Sign up
Anthropic	Claude CLI	claude.ai
Google	Gemini CLI	gemini.google.com
OpenAI	Codex CLI	platform.openai.com

2. Install WSL2 and Open Terminal

Step 1 — Open PowerShell as Administrator:

Press **Win + X** → click **Windows PowerShell (Admin)** or **Terminal (Admin)**.

Step 2 — Install WSL2 with Ubuntu:

```
wsl --install
```

This installs WSL2 + Ubuntu automatically. It will ask you to restart your computer.

Step 3 — After restart:

Ubuntu setup opens automatically. Create your Linux username and password:

```
Enter new UNIX username: yourname
New password: ••••••••
```

The password won't show as you type — that's normal. Press Enter when done.

From now on, all commands run in this Ubuntu window (not PowerShell).

Step 4 — Open WSL terminal anytime:

Press **Win**, type **Ubuntu**, press **Enter**.

Verify: You see a prompt like `yourname@DESKTOP:~$`

3. Install Node.js

Inside your Ubuntu (WSL2) terminal:

```
sudo apt update
sudo apt install -y nodejs npm
```

Verify:

```
node --version
```

Expected: `v18.x.x` or higher. If v16 or lower:

```
curl -fsSL https://deb.nodesource.com/setup_20.x | sudo -E bash -  
sudo apt install -y nodejs
```

4. Install AI CLIs

Claude CLI:

```
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code  
claude
```

A browser window opens on Windows → log in with Anthropic account → return to Ubuntu terminal.

Verify: `claude --version`

Gemini CLI:

```
npm install -g @google/gemini-cli  
gemini
```

Browser opens → log in with Google account.

Verify: `gemini --version`

Codex CLI:

```
npm install -g @openai/codex  
codex
```

Browser opens → log in with OpenAI account.

Verify: `codex --version`

5. Set Up Your Workspace

```
mkdir -p ~/projects/my-product/.pm/artifacts  
cd ~/projects/my-product
```

Note: Your Linux home directory (`~/`) is stored inside WSL2 — it's separate from your Windows `C:\Users\` folder. This is intentional and keeps things clean.

Verify: `ls .pm/` → shows `artifacts/`

6. Load Your Product Context

```
nano .pm/STATE.md
```

Paste and fill in:

```
- Product: [your product name]
- Phase: Discover
- Sprint: 1 (ends 2026-06-01)
- Focus: [what you're working on this sprint]
- Blockers: none

## Context
[2-3 sentences about your product: what it does, who uses it, current stage.]
```

Save: **Ctrl+O** → **Enter** → **Ctrl+X**

Verify: `cat .pm/STATE.md`

7. Install headless-pm

```
npx headless-pm install
```

Enter your license key when prompted (or press Enter for free skills).

8. First Run

```
cd ~/projects/my-product
claude
```

Inside Claude Code:

```
/pm
```

You'll see the PM dashboard. Try:

```
/pm-prd      # write a PRD
/cusdev      # customer interview prep
/pm-sprint-plan # plan your sprint
```

Troubleshooting (Windows WSL2)

Problem	Fix
<code>wsl --install</code> fails	Make sure Windows is updated to version 2004 or later (Win+R → <code>winver</code>).
After restart, Ubuntu doesn't open automatically	Press Win → type Ubuntu → Enter.

<code>node --version</code> shows v16 or lower	Install Node.js 20 via NodeSource (see Step 3).
Permission error on <code>npm install -g</code>	Add <code>sudo</code> prefix.
Browser doesn't open during CLI login	Run the command, copy the URL it prints, paste it in your Windows browser manually.
Can't find files in Windows Explorer	Your WSL files are at <code>\\wsl\$\\Ubuntu\\home\\yourname\\</code> in File Explorer.
<code>/pm</code> shows "No skills found"	Run <code>npx headless-pm install</code> again.